OPERATIONAL MEASUREMENT

Your Team Saved 20 Minutes. The Customer Waited Another Day.

What to measure when a change makes one part of the job faster.



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A commercial contractor introduces a proposal tool. Estimates that used to take an hour to format now take 40 minutes. The sales lead has the numbers on Friday. The project manager has a different set of numbers. He spent the week checking quantities that used to arrive with the estimate, and two buyers had to wait a day for a correction.

Both people are reporting what they saw. The CEO has to decide whether the firm got better at getting a usable proposal to the buyer.

To measure a workflow improvement, define a comparable case and record elapsed time, employee effort, quality, and what happens next. Include the people who absorb extra work. Compare the same kinds of cases before and after, and decide upfront which result would make the company keep, change, or stop the intervention.

Which numbers show what really improved?

Start with the outcome the next person needs. For a proposal, a useful endpoint might be an accurate estimate the buyer can act on. Record time from a complete request to that point, the minutes people worked, and what had to be corrected. Track waiting for the customer and waiting inside the business separately when that difference would change the diagnosis.

Think about getting a package in the product's own box. Using less packaging matters if the item still arrives intact. Amazon describes putting products on vibration tables and applying weights to simulate packages stacked above them in transit. The box has to make it through the truck, not just look ready at the packing station. The useful question for a contractor is the same. What happens to the output after your team calls its part done? Amazon's Packaging Innovation Lab

A proposal can survive formatting and fail in estimating or sales. Pick a comparable group and inspect the version that reached the buyer. Did it include the quantities sales needed to explain the price? Did the buyer ask for a correction? If a better template makes it faster to produce the first document and slower to deliver the right one, both results belong in the review.

How do you measure whether work moved to another team?

Record handling time by role and put the handoffs on the timeline. Ask each person what they now have to check, re-enter or explain. Use comparable case types, including difficult ones. The person who reports the initial saving may never see the new work.

Measure per comparable proposal	Before	During pilot
Estimator formatting time	60 min	40 min
Project manager verification time	10 min	35 min
Total handling time for those two activities	70 min	75 min
Median time to a usable proposal	1 business day	2 business days

These are illustrative figures. The estimator saves 20 minutes and the project manager spends 25 more. Together they use five extra minutes, while the buyer waits an additional day. Now investigate why the verifier is doing more. If the new tool can carry the missing quantities from the approved estimate, test that change. If the extra time is uncovering old errors the business never counted, include that improvement in the decision.

Look past the median when deadlines matter. A pilot can improve the typical case while making the hardest jobs slower. Record the number of bids that missed their deadline and what caused the misses. Keep pilot cases comparable or separate standard and complex jobs before looking at results.

What would make you keep a slower workflow?

Set the decision rule before you see the results. If the tool catches material estimate errors the company previously sent to buyers, a few extra minutes might be worth keeping. If the verification consists of copying quantities out of a second tool and yields no improvement in accuracy, it is a candidate for redesign. Look at the type and consequence of each correction before assigning a dollar value.

For example, a typo caught before issue and an omitted work package caught before a fixed-price quote are both corrections. Counting them as equal can mislead the owner. Record the omitted scope, who would have carried its cost and what the buyer was told. That evidence can support keeping the additional check while changing how the numbers reach the reviewer. The pilot decision can be to keep one part and replace another.

How do you decide whether the time saved is worth anything?

Describe what the team can do with the time it gets back. An hour an estimator can use to price a good opportunity is different from an hour spread in short interruptions across five people. Track the work that actually changes and distinguish capacity from cash costs the company can avoid.

In a **Workflow Measurement Record**, capture the case, start and end, time by role, corrections, customer outcome, and a note on exceptions. Add the cost of the tool and upkeep. If the tool frees capacity and managers use it to take more qualified jobs, observe the number and quality of those jobs. If it reduces paid overtime, record the overtime actually avoided. Either result can matter, and they answer different investment questions.

Three things to put in the next pilot report.

- The point where the buyer or next team can actually use the output.
- Time and corrections across the people doing the work.
- The condition that would make you expand, change, or stop the pilot.

At the next Friday meeting, the sales lead and project manager should be looking at the same proposals. The decision is whether your buyers can use them sooner, and what the company spent to make that happen.

Frequently asked questions

How many cases are enough to assess a change?

Use enough cases to see common variations and important exceptions. A small sample can reveal a failure and help choose a next test. A larger or longer comparison is useful when volume, seasonality, or job mix makes the effect hard to distinguish.

Is average completion time enough?

Look at the distribution, missed deadlines, and quality as well. Check whether the same types of cases went into each group.

How do you attribute the change to one tool?

Keep other conditions as stable as practical and document what else changed. A comparison against a similar group or a staggered trial can help. Treat observational results with the limits their setup warrants.

The contractor and measurements are illustrative. Amazon describes its own packaging tests in the linked source.